Cambridge
O Level

Cambridge Assessment International Education
Cambridge Ordinary Level

ENGLISH LANGUAGE **1123/22**

Paper 2 Reading **October/November 2019**

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1 hour 45 minutes

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READ THESE INSTRUCTIONS FIRST

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Passage 1

Honey

1 The production of honey has a fascinating history, as shown by a cave painting in Spain of humans foraging for honey at least 8000 years ago. Honey was a sweetening ingredient in many dishes in Greek and Egyptian cuisine, and this use is mentioned in the works of many Roman writers, such as Pliny the Elder and Virgil. Honey also features in the mythology of many civilisations. For example, in Greek mythology, the infant god Zeus was fed on honey, and the Roman goddess of the moon was often portrayed in the shape of a honey bee. The texts of many world religions contain references to honey. In the Jewish Bible, milk and honey flowed through the Promised Land, in Islam the Qur'an promotes honey as a healthy and nutritious food, and Buddha spent time in the desert where a monkey brought him honey to eat.

2 In ancient times, honey was widely used for medicinal purposes by the Egyptians, Chinese, Greeks and Romans to heal cuts and burns, for example, and to cure diseases of the intestine. It was seen to be so valuable that it was sometimes given as a precious gift. In ancient Egypt, people who worked closely with the Pharaoh were allotted daily portions of honey, and honey was given as a present to the Pharaoh by people living in outlying territories.

3 In an ancient tomb in Georgia, in Western Asia, a clay vessel was discovered which contained the oldest remains of honey ever found, revealing that honey was used there 5000 years ago as an embalming agent for the dead; this practice was also employed by the Egyptians, Babylonians and Persians. Additionally, there was an established custom among some peoples – for example, in both North and Central America – to place jars of honey in tombs as food for the afterlife. Apple slices dipped in honey during the traditional meal for Jewish New Year symbolised a sweet year ahead, and in ancient Chinese wedding ceremonies the couple sealed their wedding vows with a drink made with honey. Thus, it can be seen that honey also had a symbolic value.

4 The popularity of honey continues nowadays. Because it contains antioxidants, it may improve our bodies' immunity to many illnesses, even potentially fatal ones. It is thought that honey might be beneficial for patients recovering from illness, with one British hospital in 2006 reporting that it planned to use honey to speed up the healing process of patients after surgery. Such research may provide scientific evidence for unconfirmed beliefs, held by honey-lovers all over the world, that honey possesses healing properties. Honey mixed with lemon is a reliable cure for coughs and colds. In fact, the World Health Organisation recommends honey as a treatment for coughs and sore throats, even for young children, stating that there is no reason to believe it is less effective than any man-made remedy such as pharmaceutical medicines.

5 Honey is a source of many vitamins and minerals, the most common ones being Vitamin C, calcium and iron; other benefits depend on the type of flowers used by the bees to make their honey. In contrast, if you check the content of any other sweetener, you will find it doesn't contain any vitamins and minerals, or only very few. Because eating honey is a good way to maintain blood sugar levels and encourages muscle recuperation after a workout, it improves athletic performance.

6 Mixed with milk, honey helps to create smooth skin; consuming this combination every day is a common practice in many countries, and the best shower gels and shampoos are those advertising that they contain milk and honey. It is thought by some dieticians that, because honey contains a unique blend of natural sugars, it triggers changes in the body which ensure we won't crave other sweet foods. This claim has given rise to a weight loss programme based on honey, which supposedly makes it possible to lose more than a kilo in a week.

7 And when we realise that, even when we are not trying to lose weight, honey can be a part of our normal diet – for example by being added to tea or to various sauces and cakes – we would all agree that honey is just delicious!

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Passage 2

Hortense

1 From the age of two, the only thing I ever wanted to do was to study animals and become a zoologist. I am an exceptionally lucky person; people say that a child whose ambition is to have a particular job rarely grows up to fulfil that role. But my dream came true when I got the job I'd always wanted.

2 Throughout my formative years, I drove my family mad by catching or buying, and bringing into the house, every conceivable type of creature, ranging from monkeys to the common garden snail. My family members comforted each other with the thought that my hobby was just a phase I was passing through and that I would soon grow out of it, although they were harassed by my vast assortment of wildlife. But with each fresh acquisition my interest in animals deepened until, by my late teens, I knew without a shadow of a doubt that I wanted to be a collector of animals for zoos.

3 One day I received a phone call from a school friend who lived in the countryside and who possessed a deer, called Hortense, which he had looked after since its birth and which he described – wrongly, as I discovered later – as young. He explained that, as he was moving to a town apartment, he was unable to keep his pet, even though it was tame and house-trained, he said, and his father could deliver it to me within twenty-four hours, or even sooner. I should have picked up on his desperation to be rid of it.

4 I was in a quandary. I should have asked my mother how she felt about the addition of a deer to my already extensive animal collection, but she was not at home. However, the deer owner was clamouring for an immediate reply, saying that, unless I took it, it would have to be humanely destroyed. That clinched it. It was not a wise decision but I agreed to take Hortense the following day, without even having seen him. By the time my mother returned, I had rehearsed my story over and over again, a story that would have softened a heart of stone, much less such a susceptible one as she had. She said that to allow it to be killed was unthinkable when we could keep it in a tiny corner of the garage.

5 Hortense arrived the next day. Stepping from his truck, he delicately plucked one of my mother's prize roses, which he proceeded to chew slowly. He had a pair of horns with a forest of lethal-looking spikes, and he was about four feet high. Hurriedly, before my mother could recover from the shock of Hortense's appearance, I thanked the boy and his father profusely, attached a rope to Hortense's collar, and took him into the garage. Before I could tie him up, he spotted a wheelbarrow which he tried to toss into the air with his horns. 'I do hope he isn't going to be fierce,' said my mother worriedly. 'You know how Larry feels about fierce things.' I knew only too well how my elder brother felt about any animal, fierce or otherwise, and I was delighted that both he and my sister were out when Hortense arrived.

6 All that week I managed to keep Hortense away from my family, but my success was short-lived. One bright sunny afternoon, when Hortense and I got back from our walk, with me leading him by a rope attached to his collar, we were treated to the sight of the family seated round the garden table laden with sandwiches, teacups, cakes and a large bowl of raspberries and cream. Hortense decided that the table was a four-legged enemy, so he lowered his head and charged, whipping his rope out of my fingers. He hit the table, getting his horns tangled in the tablecloth and scattering food in all directions. My mother and sister were scalded with tea and my brother Larry was covered with raspberries and cream.

7 'This is the last straw,' roared Larry, 'so get that animal out of here!' He pointed a quivering finger at Hortense, who, astonished by the havoc he had created, was standing there demurely with the tablecloth hitched to his horns. So, in spite of my pleas, Hortense was banished to a nearby farm, and with his departure vanished my only chance of experience with large animals in the home.

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